CSC MASTER'S GUIDE · 2 OF 6

Development Impact Statement

The four-part statement the panel weights most: the problem, your route home, the change you will make and how it will be measured.

650 WORDS ACROSS 4 PARTS

4 PARTS

2 WORKED EXAMPLES

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> **About the examples.** All names, institutions, universities, academics, places and statistics below are anonymised and reinvented versions of successful Commonwealth Master's applications, changed to show technique. Yours must be real and sourced.

The live questions (2027/28). The Development Impact statement is four separate boxes.

- **Part 1 (200 words).** How does your proposed study relate to development issues at global, national and local levels, and to development issues connected to your chosen CSC theme and the wider sector?
- **Part 2 (100 words).** How do you intend to apply your new skills and qualifications when you return home?
- **Part 3 (250 words).** What do you expect will change in development terms following your studies? Include the outcomes you aim to achieve, the timeframe, and the beneficiaries.
- **Part 4 (100 words).** How could the impact of your work best be measured and evidenced?

What is being scored. The CSC's primary indicators are the need (how your plan relates to development in your sector and country), the expected outcomes, timeframe and beneficiaries, and how far you will apply new skills. Its secondary indicators include a national development priority or capacity shortage, the selected CSC theme, and how impact could be measured. The panel's own advice is that a brief statement is unlikely to be as convincing as a well-built argument that uses the full word count.

Structure. Each part has one job. Part 1 is the problem, Part 2 is the route home, Part 3 is the change, Part 4 is the proof.

Word plan.

Part	Limit	Split
1. The problem	200	Global to local zoom 90, why it persists 40, theme and sector link 70
2. The route home	100	Institution and role 40, skills from named modules 35, first target 25
3. The change	250	Outcomes with baseline and target 70, dated phases 100, beneficiaries 60, scale 20
4. The evidence	100	Primary indicators 40, secondary indicators 30, data source and checker 30

Do not repeat yourself between parts. The most common structural failure is saying the same thing in Parts 1, 2 and 3. Each part should add something the others do not. If Part 3 repeats Part 2, you have wasted a hundred marked words.

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SECTION 1

Part one: what this statement is for

The development impact criterion asks a single question: **if you are funded, will something that matters change in your country, and could anyone check?** The four parts answer it in sequence.

Part	The reader's question	Your answer is
1	Is this a real problem, and does it need this person?	A sized problem, zoomed from global to local, with a reason it persists
2	What will you do on day one?	A named institution, a role, a first target
3	What will be different, for whom, by when?	Three outcomes, three dated phases, three tiers of beneficiary
4	How will anyone know?	Indicators, data sources and a checker

What the panel penalises

The CSC's feedback names the traps. Some applicants write about how a scholarship would make them personally successful rather than how their work contributes to development. Some assume that a developmental-sounding subject is enough. Neither earns marks. Everything in this statement should point outward from you to the people and institutions that will change.

SECTION 2

Part two: choosing your problem, theme and altitude

Choose a problem you can zoom into

The statement asks for global, national and local levels, and the strongest answers use all three in order. That means your problem must exist at all three levels, and you must have a number for each. If you cannot find a local figure, your problem may be too broad, or you may need to define your locality more narrowly. A district, a settlement, a cluster or a facility is better than a country.

Choose the theme where your evidence is strongest

Most work fits two themes. A battery recycling project can sit under Science and technology for development or Strengthening resilience and response to crises. Choose according to the evidence you can bring. If your story is about supply shocks and contamination, resilience fits. If it is about engineering a new process, science and technology fits. Then name the theme in a full sentence once, in Part 1.

Choose an altitude you can defend

Aim at a level of change a single trained person can plausibly drive from the institution they will join. A district, a province, a sector within a country. "Transform healthcare in India" is not a plan. "Bring ECG triage to 40 primary clinics in two districts, then through the state health mission" is.

SECTION 3

Part three: Part 1, beat by beat (200 words)

The zoom, around 90 words

Open on the problem, sized with an exact number, then move down a level at a time.

Variant one, the zoom.

> "Cardiovascular and respiratory disease causes most deaths from non-communicable illness in my country, and an estimated one in three cases is undiagnosed until late stage. In Kesra Province the burden is heaviest in the dense settlements around the port, where air pollution, tobacco smoke and no preventive care combine."

Variant two, the contradiction.

> "Our national programme screens for hypertension at every primary clinic, yet 61 per cent of the people it finds are never followed up, because the clinic has no clinician who can read the result and act on it."

Variant three, lived experience converted.

> "I grew up in Dunmore District, where the brick kilns employ children from the age of eight. I now run the research that measures how many, and the answer is far higher than any official figure."

Variant four, the scarcity claim.

> "There are fewer than sixty clinical officers in the country with training in cardiopulmonary care, and none of them works outside the capital."

Anchor every figure. The panel cannot check a figure with no source. Name it in a clause, not a footnote: "according to the national census", "in the ministry's 2024 survey".

Why it persists, around 40 words

One or two sentences on why the problem has not been fixed. This is where you earn the national and institutional anchor the CSC lists in its criteria. Name the rule, plan or institution that fails to reach the people you care about. "The 2023 Battery Waste Management Rules recognise licensed recyclers only, so the workers who handle most of the waste cannot register."

Theme and sector, around 70 words

Name the theme in a full sentence, using the form's exact wording, and say how your study connects to the wider sector's gap. Then say in one clause why this study, and why you.

> "That is why I have chosen the theme Strengthening resilience and response to crises, and why I will study engineering and policy together, to design recycling that is safe, profitable and open to the people already doing it."

Do not restate the whole problem. The theme sentence should add the connection to the sector and to your study. It should not repeat the numbers.

SECTION 4

Part four: Part 2, beat by beat (100 words)

The shortest part has the most work to do. It answers a single question the panel can act on: where do you go and what do you do first?

The three beats.

1. **The institution and role (about 40 words).** Name the body you will join, or the district you will start in, and your role there. "I will join the Provincial Child Protection Commission as a policy analyst."
2. **The skills, from named modules (about 35 words).** Say which skills you will bring and where you learn them. "Using the policy-simulation methods taught by Professor Calder..." This is the link between your study and your impact, and it is a listed indicator.
3. **The first target (about 25 words).** A number and a date that falls inside the first year. "4,000 workers registered and 800 tonnes moved into licensed channels."

Strong versus weak.

> **Weak:** "On my return I will use my knowledge to improve healthcare and work with the government and stakeholders to make a difference."
>
> **Strong:** "Within a year I will join the Provincial Health Directorate as an analyst and use the biostatistics from my course

> to evaluate our screening programme, starting with the 40 clinics in Kesra."

Name the institutional door. "A think-tank" is a category. "The Centre for Energy and Environment Policy" is a door.

SECTION 5

Part five: Part 3, beat by beat (250 words)

The panel asks for three things here: the outcomes, the timeframe and the beneficiaries. Give each its own paragraph, and keep them tied together.

Outcomes with baseline and target, around 70 words

State two or three outcomes, each with a number, a baseline and a date.

Weak. "I want to improve livelihoods and reduce child labour."

Strong. "Within ten years I aim to bring Dunmore's child labour rate from 6.7 per cent to below 1 per cent, to enrol and retain 24,000 children currently at work, and to have the model adopted by the Commission as provincial guidance."

The three-outcome shape. The strongest answers set one outcome about people (workers integrated, children enrolled), one about the system (a rule changed, a protocol adopted) and one about the resource (a recovery rate, a cost, a coverage figure). Together they cover the individual, the institution and the sector.

Dated phases, around 100 words

Give each phase a start and end year, a place and a target. Three phases is the natural shape: a pilot, a scale-up, a system.

> "Phase one, 2028 to 2030: pilot in three clusters, 2,400 tonnes collected and 8,000 workers registered. Phase two, 2031 to 2034: 12 cities, 9,000 tonnes a year and 40,000 workers. Phase three, 2035 to 2038: full network and 92 per cent recovery."

Phase one must be small enough to be believable. The panel assesses realism. A first phase of 12 hamlets or three clusters, with a research stage first, is more credible than a first phase across a province.

Check your arithmetic. If your outcomes say 100,000 workers and your phases add to 70,000, the panel will notice. Phases should sum to the outcomes.

Beneficiaries, around 60 words

Tier them. This shows that you thought about the system, not only the target group.

Tier	Who	What they gain
Primary	The people whose circumstances change directly	Safety, income, health, a school place
Secondary	Those who deliver the change or gain indirectly	Training, larger dividends, a domestic source of materials
Tertiary	Institutions and policy-makers	Verified data and a model they can adopt

Give the primary beneficiaries a number. 75,000 workers, 24,000 children, 6,200 savings-group members. If you cannot count them, say how you will.

Scale, around 20 words

One sentence on why the model could spread: it rests on registration and tracking, not one city's geography, or it works with institutions that already exist.

SECTION 6

Part six: Part 4, beat by beat (100 words)

This is the part applicants skip, and it is a listed indicator: the extent of benefit and how impact could be measured. Panels trust applicants who say how they could be proved wrong.

The two-level structure.

1. **Primary indicators (about 40 words).** Whether the intervention works. Workers registered, tonnes collected, share of children working, recovery rate.
2. **Secondary indicators (about 30 words).** Whether lives change. Income, injuries, school completion, dropout.
3. **Data source and checker (about 30 words).** Where the numbers come from and who verifies them. A dashboard, a school census, household surveys, a statistics office, an audit.

Name the instrument.

> "Annual School Census completion and dropout ratios will be compared with similar villages outside the pilot, and the Provincial Statistics Office will verify the results."

Include a feedback loop. "I will publish results each year so partners can check my claims" or "regular reviews will let me adapt the intervention". It shows accountability, which is in the heading of this part.

Do not invent an indicator. Use what your work genuinely produces. A real qualitative outcome beats an invented number.

SECTION 7

Part seven: two full sample sets

Sample set one, battery circularity (theme: Strengthening resilience and response to crises)

Bracketed labels show structure. Do not include them. All names are invented.

Sample one, Part 1 — 199 words · limit 200

Electric mobility is creating a waste problem that adopting countries are least equipped to manage. Emerging economies are projected to retire 9.4 million tonnes of lithium-ion batteries by 2030. My country alone will retire 212,000 tonnes of electric three-wheeler batteries a year by 2032, yet licensed plants can process only 11 per cent of that. **Global and national**

The rest moves through informal workshops. In Ashbury Yard, Port Marrow, 38,000 workers break open batteries by hand, and acid run-off has contaminated the canal that irrigates the city's market gardens. Every gram of battery-grade lithium and cobalt is imported, so each battery dismantled informally also sends recoverable metal and foreign exchange abroad. The 2023 Battery Waste Management Rules recognise licensed recyclers only, so the workers who handle most of the waste have no route into the system. **Local, and why it persists**

This is a resilience problem. A break in imported mineral supply, or a spill in a dense settlement, would hit workers, farmers and manufacturers together. That is why I have chosen the theme Strengthening resilience and response to crises, and why I will study engineering and policy together at Westmoor University, to design recycling that is safe, profitable and open to the people already doing it. **Theme and sector**

Sample one, Part 2 — 97 words · limit 100

Within a year of returning I will join the Centre for Energy and Environment Policy (CEEP), a Port Marrow think-tank, as a circular-economy analyst. Using the policy-simulation methods taught by Professor Ines Calder, I will model how the Battery Waste Management Rules would change if informal workshops could register as collection partners, and present the results to the Ministry of Environment. In parallel I will run the first pilot in Ashbury Yard: 4,000 workers registered and 800 tonnes of battery waste moved into licensed channels, tracked through a battery passport, a digital record that follows each battery.

Sample one, Part 3 230 words · limit 250

Over ten years I aim for three outcomes: 75,000 informal workers in certified operations, 9,000 tonnes of battery waste a year collected formally, and 92 per cent recovery of lithium, cobalt and nickel through closed-loop recycling, in line with the National Circular Economy Roadmap 2040. Today no informal worker can register, and licensed plants have capacity for 11 per cent of retired batteries. **Outcomes and baseline**

Phase one, 2028 to 2030, is a pilot in three recycling clusters beginning with Ashbury Yard, run through CEEP: 2,400 tonnes collected and 8,000 workers trained and registered. Phase two, 2031 to 2034, scales to 12 cities with recyclers and vehicle makers as partners, reaching 9,000 tonnes a year and 40,000 workers. Phase three, 2035 to 2038, completes the network and adopts the improved recovery methods tested in phase two, reaching 75,000 workers and 92 per cent recovery. **Dated phases**

Primary beneficiaries are the 75,000 informal workers, who move from unsafe, unrecorded work to protective equipment, training and social-security access. Secondary beneficiaries are small manufacturers, who gain a domestic source of recovered metal, and households that return used batteries for a refund. Tertiary beneficiaries are residents of recycling neighbourhoods, whose air and water improve, and the Ministry of Environment, which gains data it does not currently hold. **Beneficiaries**

Because the model rests on registration and tracking rather than one city's geography, it can be replicated in other manufacturing waste streams. **Scale**

Sample one, Part 4 100 words · limit 100

Evidence will sit at two levels. Primary indicators test whether the intervention works: informal workers registered each year, tonnes collected as a percentage of batteries retired, and the percentage of lithium, cobalt and nickel recovered. CEEP will draw these from battery passports and cluster-level audits. Secondary indicators test whether lives change: the share of recycled batteries returned to use, battery-related fires and injuries recorded at clinics, and changes in registered workers' income and social-security enrolment. Annual household surveys and incident reports will supply these, and I will publish results each year so partners and the Ministry can check my claims.

Sample set two, child labour (theme: Access, inclusion and opportunity)

Sample two, Part 1 191 words · limit 200

Child labour affects roughly one child in ten worldwide. My country's last census recorded 8.4 million child workers, and reform has stalled because inspectors visit most worksites less than once a year. In Tarn Province 3.1 per cent of children aged five to fourteen work. In Dunmore District, where I grew up, the figure is 6.7 per cent, and the brick kilns that dominate its economy employ an estimated 24,000 children. **Global, national, local**

Dunmore shows why national policy has not worked. Power over land, kilns and local officials sits with a few families, so those with the most to lose from enforcement control whether it happens. Policy is written for the average child, while the children at risk are concentrated in perhaps 200 hamlets that no one has mapped. Kiln owners are also the local lenders, so many families repay debts with their children's labour. **Why it persists**

Under the theme Access, inclusion and opportunity, I will study public policy at Halden University to learn public finance, evidence-based reform and econometric methods, so that Dunmore's savings groups, schools and officials can be brought into one system that keeps children in class and out of the kilns. **Theme and sector**

Sample two, Part 2 94 words · limit 100

On return I will join the Provincial Child Protection Commission as a policy analyst and use the econometric methods from my course to test, in my home district, a model that links the annual dividends of women's savings groups to their children's school attendance. I will design it with the Dunmore Women's Savings Federation, whose 310 groups already hold the community's trust, and pair it with a reporting system in which villagers are rewarded for flagging children out of school. Methods, partners and a first cluster of villages will be agreed within six months.

Sample two, Part 3 244 words · limit 250

Within ten years I aim to bring Dunmore's child labour rate from 6.7 per cent to below 1 per cent, to enrol and retain 24,000 children currently at work, and to have the model adopted by the Commission as provincial guidance. I also want villagers to report cases themselves, so that enforcement no longer depends on inspectors who rarely visit. **Outcomes**

Year one is research: a survey of 60 villages and GIS mapping of kiln hamlets to find the 200 or so highest-risk hamlets. Year two is a pilot in 12 of them, linking dividends to school attendance and launching community reporting. Years three to five extend the model across Dunmore with the Commission, with measurable falls in child labour and rises in attendance expected by year five. Years six to ten extend it to the rest of Tarn Province. Each phase ends with a public review alongside the Commission, so that results are checked before the model grows. **Timeline**

Primary beneficiaries are the children working in kilns, who gain a school place and a childhood. Secondary beneficiaries are the women in the 310 savings groups, around 6,200 members, whose groups gain larger and more predictable dividends. Tertiary beneficiaries are district officials and the Commission, who gain a verified, mapped picture of where children are at risk, which they do not currently have. **Beneficiaries**

Because the model uses institutions that already exist, savings groups and village schools, it can be repeated in other districts at low cost. **Scale**

Sample two, Part 4 97 words · limit 100

Impact will be measured at two levels. Primary indicators: the share of working children in the mapped hotspots, the number of women organised into savings groups, and the annual growth of their dividends, tracked on a GIS dashboard shared with the Commission. Secondary indicators: school completion, dropout and enrolment ratios from the Annual School Census, compared with similar villages outside the pilot. Pre- and post-intervention surveys in every phase will evidence change independently, and the Provincial Statistics Office will verify the results. I will also use my study year to refine these methods and protect children's data.

What both sets do. They zoom from a global figure to a named local place. They explain why the problem persists by naming a rule or an incentive. They name the theme once, in a full sentence. They name an institution and a role in Part 2, and a first target. They give baselines, targets and dates in Part 3, tier their beneficiaries, and keep their phases consistent with their outcomes. They separate indicators into two levels and name who verifies the data.

SECTION 8

Part eight: dos and don'ts

Do

- Zoom from global to national to local with a sourced number at each level
- Say why the problem persists, naming a rule, plan or incentive
- Name the theme in the form's wording, in one full sentence
- Name the institution and role you will take on return
- Link your skills to named modules or academics
- Give every main outcome a baseline, a target and a date
- Tier your beneficiaries and count the primary tier
- Make your phases add up to your outcomes
- Separate primary and secondary indicators and name the data source
- Say who will check the results

Don't

- Write about how the scholarship will advance your career
- Assume the subject is developmental by nature
- Repeat the same content across the four parts
- Use a global statistic with no local counterpart
- Promise outcomes with no baseline
- Invent indicators you could not collect
- Name five initiatives where one would do
- Write "paradigm shift", "transformative" or "revolutionise"
- Skip Part 4 or make it three lines

SECTION 9

Part nine: common mistakes, and the fix

Mistake	Why it costs marks	The fix
Part 1 is all global statistics	No local need, so the panel cannot see where you will work	Zoom down to a named district or cluster with a figure
"Millions of people will benefit."	No beneficiary can be counted or checked	Give the primary tier a number and a place
A target with no baseline	The change cannot be measured	State today's figure, the target and the date
Phases that do not add up to the outcome	The plan looks invented	Sum your phases and check them against the outcomes
"I will work with the government."	No route home	Name the institution, the role and the first target
Skills named without modules	The link between study and impact is asserted	Name the module or academic that teaches each skill
Parts 2 and 3 repeat each other	A hundred marked words wasted	Part 2 is day one, Part 3 is the ten-year change
Part 4 lists vague KPIs	Impact cannot be tested	Name the indicator, the source and the checker
The theme named three times	Reads as filler	Name it once in Part 1
Personal career goals dominate	The panel wants development impact	Rewrite every sentence from the beneficiary's side
Five named programmes	A brochure, not a plan	Choose one flagship and name it consistently
Acronyms undefined	The panel is not expert in your field	Define on first use, in a few words

SECTION 10

Part ten: checklists

While drafting

- A global, national and local figure, each sourced
- One sentence on why the problem persists, naming a rule or institution
- The theme named once, in the form's wording
- Part 2 names the institution, the role and the first target
- Skills in Part 2 tied to named modules or academics
- Three outcomes, each with a baseline, a target and a date
- Three dated phases that sum to the outcomes
- Three tiers of beneficiary, with the primary tier counted
- Two levels of indicator, with data sources and a checker
- One line on scale or replication

Before submitting

- No repetition between the four parts
- Every figure sourced and every name spelled correctly
- No claim about personal success in place of development impact
- Every acronym defined on first use
- The full word count used in each part
- The route home in Part 2 matches the career plans and the study plan
- A national anchor named: a rule, plan or capacity shortage
- Nothing here contradicts my employment entries or personal statement
- I could defend every number if asked